

Cooperative Usability Study

Washington, DC

January 8, 2020 & January 21, 2020

Study Information

In this study, Flexion UX Designers performed an end-to-end testing of a U.S. Tax Court case workflow in order to validate system features and handoffs between roles at the Court.

Participants

Representatives from each of the following user roles were present at the roundtable:

- Petitions Clerk
- Docket Clerk
- ADC
- Judge
- Chambers Administrator
- Calendar Clerk

Sessions

Four two-hour roundtables session were held on-site at the U.S. Tax Court. All participants were in one room, sharing their screens as they worked via a Zoom meeting.

Key Findings

- Overall, roles were able to complete their normal functions and major functionality worked as expected
- Participants were able to easily navigate the system (even without prior training)
- Petition batch process / order generation is a new process for petitions clerks; current workflow requires some updates to meet their needs/expectations
- When drafting orders, judges want easier access to the docket record and previous documents on the case (split screen)
- Participants were able to communicate with each other via the messages function, but there is a disconnect between original messages and subsequent actions/documents generated (i.e., original message is attached to Motion; Judge creates Order in response to Motion and now creates a new message thread)
- Docket/Calendar Clerk needs easier access to party address and service information from their QC screens; an easier way to create a split screen/multi-tab experience would be beneficial
- Docket Clerks need more flexibility around automated minute entries
- When you hit cancel on PDF upload error, it makes you go all the way back to the beginning and start over in the form; need a better way to inform user of issues/failures with the PDF uploads without making them re-enter form info

Recommendations - High Priority

- Update Order title field / order document type to prevent duplicate “ORDER” language on docket entry (HIGH)
- Update petition > order workflow to guide clerks to create all orders required for a case before serving (HIGH)
- Consider easier method to create split-screen view, especially for docket record navigation, order creation, and document QC (HIGH)
- Limit character count on all date fields / consider auto-tab (HIGH)
- Revise messaging flow to allow message threads to span or link across multiple documents (HIGH)
- Add ability to send bulk notices for cases on a trial session (HIGH- Post-MVP)
- In the processed tab of Petitions, show any orders served with the petition (HIGH)
- Need ability to serve externally filed paper documents (HIGH)
- Need to redesign the upload failure dialog and retain information entered in the Petition Form (validating pdfs when uploaded) (HIGH)

Recommendations

- Update “Create Order” screens to allow users to navigate and preview other documents in the docket record while drafting the order text
- Add ability to include free text on Notice of Docket Change to give context around why items were changed
- Add option to choose if an automatic minute entry should be created when action is taken (filing fee update, address updates, etc.)
- Add “digits” to docket clerk names in all dropdowns
- Add bar number to practitioner names across application
- Provide better wayfinding from trial session to case and back
- Reorder options in party types in dropdown: myself, myself and spouse, and corporation should be first
- Generate new cover sheet when petition received / file date is updated
- Need to account for petitions mailed in previous year but created in system in current year; docket number needs to be manually edited/added

Recommendations

- Clear dynamic fields when a new selection is made (order checkbox didn't clear when Paid was selected)
- Consider revising the print Petition Receipt flow (TBD - dependent on discussion about real-time petition service)
- Add ability to replace PDF on existing docket entry
- Ensure that Served and Parties columns are being populated on docket record when Petition and any orders served with the petition are served in batch
- If externally filed document with COS - should not have served or parties fields populated in docket record (per Cheryl)
- Add ability to create a dual case status on a case (i.e., could be Calendared and Assigned-Motion)
- Add ability to manipulate PDF document orientation (Available via PDF viewer - train users)

Recommendations: Design Updates

- Print paper service screen - needs the “Actions” button in header
- Serve to parties button should be single line and have an icon
- Permission Update - Case Services Director - needs access to Petition Document QC - (HIGH)
- Update label on Save and/or Serve buttons on Add Docket Entry screen
- Update scan interface; decrease height on box to minimize blank space
- On deadlines area, fix extra spacing between edit/delete links
- On Draft Order page, the edit/delete actions get lost - look at different placement
- Update sort order on Document Type so Answer is first in list when listed
- Add standard message text options, similar to their current “For Action”
- Update “Complete” tab label to “Completed”

Findings | Comprehensive Findings

Findings (January 8)

Order Generation

- When Order (O) is selected - the document title should just say "ORDER" - the docket record should have option to include additional order title description
 - "Order title" field should be optional when creating the order draft
- From Messages - draft order should go to Draft Order - Docket view with the add docket entry option - clerk would expect to see all options
- Petition Order process
 - Petition clerk orders - Confirm when petition created order that it is batched and included with peititon - all in one piece when served to IRS
 - Order- when petitions clerk serves - the order is showing as served instead of batched
 - If there are multiple orders, would prefer to go back to the Order Summary screen
 - Jessica having meeting with IRS about real-time service of petitions - may eliminate some of the issues with batching petitions and orders
 - Served petition and orders: would want to see individual documents within each case - could be nested
 - If petition requires order, clerks want to QC petition, create all orders, and then serve everything at one time
- Generic create order - order name should not be part of order body. The title name should be Create Order and not pull the open text field
- Judge - draft an order - uses two separate screens - wants to see order he's drafting. However, is familiar with how to open another tab; but doesn't really like it. Doesn't feel that others know how to do this. Possible solution: automatically launch the Create Order screen in a new tab

Findings (January 8)

Document Detail

- Would like to be able to change orientation of PDF - if PDF was uploaded upside down
- Anytime there is a COS - Docket checks against the petitioner address
 - Address needs to be accessible from any document detail - docket QC screen
- Calendar Clerk - Need to compare against documents/ case info for spelling, filing fee was it paid or not, was the petition timely (add to document detail page)

Notice of Docket Change

- If COS is not accepted - they currently create a Notice of Docket - works
 - They need to be able to enter text of what is wrong - why they changed the docket entry
- Notice of Docket Change - Buch wants it to be more descriptive - just saying that it's been changed

Minute Entries

- When the application for filing fee is granted - there is an order and then when they notate the fee was waived/paid
 - there is automatically a minute entry created - they need to be able to select whether or not there should be a minute entry

Date Field

- Need to update all date components- limit character count

Findings (January 8)

Messaging

- ADC did not complete original message so it remained in the Inbox - she sent a new message
- Messaging issue - if Motion is sent to Judge as message - he created order and then needs to create a new message - now these messages aren't tied together
- Order - Draft - responding to a motion - creates a draft - expects to reply to the message but it's a new message thread with an order. In current system, all he has to do is reply to the motion after creating the order; Judge likes message connected to an order.

Display Names

- Need to add the docket clerk "digits" to their names in dropdowns
- Petitioner counsel - practitioner name should show bar number on Open Cases

Calendar QC

- Calendar QC - no easy way to get back to the calendar once you get into a case; have to use back button
- Reviewing petition doc and needs to see the docket record to compare
 - Needs to see all docket information
- Generating - a Notice Reminding the Parties of Trial - has to create them individually
- After trial session is created and location is changed, need to send out notices again. Have we gotten to this? Users aren't going to want to send out 100 individual notices

Findings (January 8)

Petition QC

- Tina asked for petitions when entering if we can reorder myself, myself and spouse and cooperation and bring them to the top of drop down. These are the 3 most common. Type-ahead doesn't matter what at top.
- Petition QC- should default to Document Info tab - not working
- If date received/ filed date is changed during petition QC - does it create a new cover sheet??
- Issue - petitions in late 2019 but created in 2020 will have docket number in 2020 - need to correct before 2021
- Filing fee - dynamic fields should clear when other radio button is selected (order checkbox didn't clear when Paid was selected)
- "If everything looks right, I can complete, right?" Clicks on completed in messages (did not understand what to expect under completed messages)
- Didn't notice scroll on data fields. Was going to create case with missing data
- Filed all the papers together, instead of one at a time.
- Having to go to messages to get confirmation doesn't make sense to Justine. Once the batch is processed, would be easier to get the receipt right away instead of going in one into the next.
- Sidenote - prompt users to enter immediately - like docket instead of orders needed screen.

Findings (January 8)

Add Docket Entry

- Scan interface - decrease height on scanned batches - too much blank space below scan pushes document preview down
- MVP? Replacing, editing PDFs on current docket entry
 - example - if petitioner includes the STIN with their Petition
- Save versus Serve buttons - Is unsure of whether to add docket entry and then serve or visa versus (could change label on button to clarify)

Service

- Petition and anything else in batch - need to make sure the Parties column is populated on docket record
- If externally filed document with COS - should not have served or parties fields populated in docket record (per Cheryl)

Bulk Notices

Subsequent notices on cases set for trial

- Notice reminding parties of trial - will this be a bulk action across all cases on a trial session
- Is it MVP to be able to send bulk notices after the calendar is set

Case Status

- Assigned - Motion - need to also see that a case is “Calendared” - could have a dual status - happens once or twice a year
- When case status is changed to Assigned - Motion - the case is removed from Calendar
 - Can use case notes to ensure that clerks add the case back to trial after motion is resolved - need to have ability for dual status post-mvp

Findings (January 8)

Design Updates

- Print paper service screen - needs the "Actions" button in header
- Serve to parties button should be single line and have an icon
- Flow/Design update needed: When you hit cancel on PDF upload error, it makes you go all the way back to the beginning and start over in the form
- Need to redesign the upload failure dialog
- Need to update process- so when cancel upload it just takes you back to the review page
- Permission Update - Case Services Director - needs access to Petition Document QC
- Draft Order - success message - should be moved above title - gets confusing
- Draft order - success message needs to be revised - your filing has been successfully submitted- makes it seem final

Bugs / Issues

- Error occurred while uploading a document. Firewall issue?
 - Masking the request with some other URL that we don't have - that's not in our system.
 - Deborah - will send PDF
- BUG - Red star bold on new item in docket record still displaying as new after it has been opened and edited
- Joe added an order, but it's not displaying in the document view (resolved after refresh)
- BUG: Carluzzo- message sent by ADC not showing on dashboard recent messages - but shows in Inbox
- Petition QC screens should default to Document Info tab (BUG)

Other Areas of Concern (January 8)

- Carluzzo concern - doesn't want system to time out
- Would like order templates
- Other concern from calendar - being in the case at the same time

Findings (January 21)

Orders

- For generic “O” orders - don’t pull “Order” automatically into the docket entry; it’s creating a duplicate
- ADC - always prints the docket record for every case before she takes action to create an order
 - Scrolling through PDF viewer - “cumbersome”
 - Navigating docket while drafting order- needs access to see the docket record itself AND the PDF documents - did not refresh the Quick Preview at all while drafting the order -may be more important to see the docket record/PDF

Case Detail

- Docket clerk- if case is calendared - would like easier access to that information - date at minimum
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Create Case / Add Docket Entry

- Update Mailing date to “Mailed Date”

Service

- Paper external documents require service option when adding to docket entry (HIGH - MVP)

Findings (January 21)

Design Updates

- Answer should be easier to locate in dropdown - can we change sort order so Answer displays first
- Tab wanted for date fields, validation or restriction needed for date fields
- Some users had trouble finding service and petitioner information - had trouble clicking around Case Detail tabs
- Sending message- currently they have a “for action” - may be nice to have standard messages as well as ability to free text (post-mvp)
- Refresh on Create Order - no one intuitively knows to click it - if you click View Full PDF - it still requires you to refresh first
- Complete messages (thread) - word “Complete” is throwing people off - think it’s an action

Findings (January 21)

Bugs

- Not displaying PDF consistently - could be related to court network or device setup; not happening on all court computers (Added to Trello for tracking)
- On QC Complete - the paper service modal should not be displaying for externally filed document (Added to Trello)
- File a Document Wizard- free text field (Motion to Dismiss for Lack of Jurisdiction as to ...) did not update when continued to step 2, went back to step 1 and updated field and continued again (Added to Trello)
- New message icon isn't showing in header consistently; sometimes shows only when you click into "Messages" screen (Add to Trello)
- Checkbox clickable areas are too large (example, clicking outside of the Attachments box is still marking it as checked (Added to Trello)
- System keeps logging users out of system (Added to Trello)
 - Docket clerk logged out when clicked Serve from add docket entry - paper service modal and did not save any of the changes or serve the document
 - ADC logged out when applying signature to order
 - Docket clerk - clicking on Document QC - got logged out
 - Judge logged out when navigating to Trial Sessions from main navigation

Findings (January 21)

Bugs

- Add Trial Session form - clerk typing in address fields when suddenly the app navigated back to Trial Sessions screen and had saved the trial session before the clerk clicked “Add Session” (Added to Trello)
- Remove “Your name” in care of field (Added to Trello)
- Cover sheet for Petition is showing Petitioner(s) plural even though caption is showing singular - (Added to Trello)
- Add Deadline modal - date field is weird - needs spaces between fields (Added to Trello)
- BUG - Petition is showing as not QC’d in docket record even after it’s been batched (159-20)- (added to Trello)
- Motion - completing QC is prompting print paper service - should not display this message for e-filed documents other than automated notices (Added to Trello)
- Need to clear success message when you tab to new tab in Case Detail (Added to Trello)

Questions | Come on, let us have 'em!

Appendix